FLOOD RISK, RANKED

50 Florida beach towns, and how much of each one the water reaches.



Mark and Betsy Scott

WHY FLOOD RISK BELONGS ON YOUR LIST

Choosing a Florida beach town is about the life you want: morning walks on the sand, a good fish taco, friends nearby and a pace that suits you. But the same water that makes these towns beautiful can also come into the streets.

Before you fall in love with a neighborhood, it is worth knowing how often the ocean is likely to visit it, and how the federal government officially maps its flood risk.

This guide looks at two different kinds of flood risk. The first is the ocean itself: everyday high tides, the extra high "King Tides" that flood some streets on sunny fall days, and storm surge pushed ashore by hurricanes. The second is FEMA's official high risk flood map, the one lenders use.

The two do not always agree, so we combine them into one simple score from 1 to 10.

Use the ranking as one piece of the puzzle, not the whole answer. A town near the top can still be a wonderful fit if you choose higher ground, a newer elevated home or a condo above the ground floor. A town near the bottom still floods in some spots. Pair this list with what matters most to you, and look at the exact street before you buy.



Seven Mile Bridge, Marathon. No. 2 of 50 for flood risk.

QUICK TIP

Not sure which towns fit your lifestyle yet? Take the free 8 question beach town quiz at floridacoastal.co, then check your matches here.

TWO MAPS, ONE SCORE

1 Tide flooding · the ocean coming in

How much of a town goes underwater when the tide rises 1, 2 or 3 feet above recent normal high tide (MHHW). It shows which streets flood on sunny King Tide days and in storm surge. Only land connected to the ocean is counted. The ranking uses the +3 ft figure.

Example: Marathon 57.9%



24.8% under water at +1 ft, 37.4% at +2 ft, 57.9% at +3 ft

+1 ft above recent normal high tide · +2 ft · +3 ft · FEMA high risk zone

2 FEMA high risk zone · the official map

The share of a town inside FEMA's Special Flood Hazard Area: land with at least a 1% chance of flooding in any year, where mortgages require flood insurance. Zones A and AE are mostly rain and river flooding; Zone VE is coastal storm surge with waves.

FEMA's map does not include normal daily tides or future sea level rise, which is why it can tell a different story from the tide map.

3 Combined Flood Score · 1 to 10

Both measures above, given equal weight, turned into one score where 10 is the highest risk among these 50 towns. The next page shows exactly how it works.

1.0 · 2.0 · 3.0 · 4.0 · 5.0 · 6.0 · 7.0 · 8.0 · 9.0 · 10.0

HOW THE COMBINED SCORE WORKS

The score compares each town to the other 49 on this list. It is a ranking, not a prediction of whether a particular home will flood.

1

Rank on tide flooding

Each town gets a percentile from 0 to 100 based on how much of its land is under water at +3 ft above recent normal high tide (100 = the most).

2

Rank on the FEMA map

Each town gets a second percentile from 0 to 100 based on how much of its land is in FEMA's high risk zone. Towns that tie share the same percentile.

3

Average and scale

The two percentiles are averaged with equal weight and scaled to 1 to 10: score = 1 + 9 × (average / 100). 10 = highest risk.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Santa Rosa Beach (30A)

5.2
rank 29 of 50

Land under water at +3 ft	**7.4%**	Tide percentile	**38.8**
Land in FEMA high risk zone	**53.5%**	FEMA percentile	**55.1**
Average	**(38.8 + 55.1) / 2 = 46.95**	Score	**1 + 9 × 0.4695 = 5.23**

In plain English: Santa Rosa Beach has less tide prone land than most towns on the list, a bit more FEMA high risk land than average, and lands right in the middle at 5.2.

GOOD TO KNOW

Median elevation is shown in the rankings for information only. It is not part of the score.

Neither map counts heavy rain flooding, like Palm Bay's Nov 2, 2026 deluge. A low score does not mean a street never floods in a downpour.

ALL 50 TOWNS, RANKED

Highest risk first

+1 ft above recent normal high tide · +2 ft · +3 ft · FEMA high risk zone

RANK	TOWN	SCORE	LAND UNDER WATER AT +3 FT	LAND IN FEMA HIGH RISK ZONE	MEDIAN ELEVATION
1	Anna Maria	9.9	47.2%	99.9%	3 ft
2	Marathon	9.7	57.9%	99.8%	2.5 ft
3	Sanibel	9.3	46.1%	99.6%	2.4 ft
4	Fort Myers Beach	9.0	36.5%	99.8%	4 ft
5	Islamorada	8.6	46.3%	91.0%	4.2 ft
6	Bradenton Beach	8.6	33.6%	98.4%	3.5 ft
7	Miami Beach	8.5	40.4%	95.3%	3.5 ft
8	Marco Island	8.5	39.9%	95.8%	4.1 ft
9	Key West	8.3	42.5%	88.3%	3.5 ft
10	Treasure Island	8.3	19.0%	99.9%	4.4 ft
11	Cedar Key	8.2	41.6%	87.1%	5.2 ft
12	St. Pete Beach	8.2	20.3%	99.8%	4.4 ft
13	Navarre Beach	7.9	23.0%	96.8%	12.6 ft
14	Siesta Key	7.6	15.5%	98.1%	4.2 ft
15	Longboat Key	7.5	22.7%	95.0%	4 ft
16	St. Augustine	7.1	26.2%	59.7%	6.2 ft
17	Pensacola Beach	7.1	14.8%	93.1%	14.1 ft
18	Flagler Beach	6.4	29.9%	45.4%	5.9 ft
19	Palm Beach	6.4	13.4%	62.7%	5.7 ft
20	Naples	6.3	11.1%	76.9%	6.4 ft
21	Cocoa Beach	6.2	31.7%	44.4%	4 ft
22	Jacksonville Beach	5.8	24.7%	38.9%	13.1 ft
23	Apalachicola	5.8	23.3%	44.0%	12.9 ft
24	Hallandale Beach	5.8	7.7%	71.1%	5.2 ft
25	New Smyrna Beach	5.5	10.8%	50.4%	21.9 ft

ALL 50 TOWNS, CONTINUED

Highest risk first

+1 ft above recent normal high tide · +2 ft · +3 ft · FEMA high risk zone

RANK	TOWN	SCORE	LAND UNDER WATER AT +3 FT	LAND IN FEMA HIGH RISK ZONE	MEDIAN ELEVATION
26	Hollywood	5.5	10.6%	51.2%	6.7 ft
27	Fort Lauderdale	5.4	5.0%	60.5%	5.9 ft
28	Cape Coral	5.2	13.1%	44.6%	8.2 ft
29	Santa Rosa Beach (30A)	5.2	7.4%	53.5%	24.1 ft
30	Ormond Beach	4.8	11.9%	33.3%	21.7 ft
31	Mexico Beach	4.4	1.0%	55.4%	19.7 ft
32	Fernandina Beach	4.2	8.9%	26.7%	23.5 ft
33	Sarasota	3.7	4.1%	25.8%	19 ft
34	Vero Beach	3.6	8.1%	18.4%	15.8 ft
35	Pompano Beach	3.6	1.0%	44.9%	10.3 ft
36	Daytona Beach	3.5	0.5%	50.1%	26.6 ft
37	Panama City Beach	3.3	0.3%	50.1%	31.4 ft
38	Clearwater	3.1	2.9%	19.0%	46.9 ft
39	Venice	3.1	1.6%	23.6%	12.7 ft
40	West Palm Beach	3.1	0.3%	47.4%	16.2 ft
41	Satellite Beach	2.7	3.7%	10.2%	6.3 ft
42	Fort Pierce	2.7	1.6%	15.9%	16.5 ft
43	Boca Raton	2.6	0.8%	25.7%	12.3 ft
44	Destin	2.5	1.1%	16.2%	30.3 ft
45	Delray Beach	2.4	1.5%	13.1%	15.5 ft
46	Palm Bay	2.3	0.2%	29.3%	22.5 ft
47	Jupiter	2.2	1.6%	8.8%	13.1 ft
48	Melbourne	2.1	0.4%	20.7%	20.9 ft
49	Fort Walton Beach	1.9	0.9%	11.8%	35.5 ft
50	Stuart	1.5	0.7%	4.3%	11.5 ft

THE FLOODS PEOPLE REMEMBER

The past is not the forecast, but it tells you how a place has been tested. Notable floods for each town, highest risk first.

1. Anna Maria
Hurricane Helene surge, Sep 2024; Milton, Oct 2024

2. Marathon
Hurricane Irma, Sep 2017; Wilma surge, Oct 2005

3. Sanibel
Hurricane Ian surge, Sep 2022 (Sanibel Causeway cut); Helene and Milton, 2024

4. Fort Myers Beach
Hurricane Ian surge, Sep 28 2022 (town largely destroyed); Milton, Oct 2024

5. Islamorada
1935 Labor Day Hurricane (Cat 5, Upper Keys); Hurricane Irma, Sep 2017

6. Bradenton Beach
Hurricane Helene surge, Sep 2024; Milton, Oct 2024

7. Miami Beach
Recurring king-tide (sunny-day) flooding each fall; Hurricane Irma surge, Sep 2017

8. Marco Island
Hurricane Ian, Sep 2022; Irma landfall, Sep 2017

9. Key West
Hurricane Wilma surge, Oct 2005; Irma, Sep 2017; Ian surge, Sep 2022

10. Treasure Island
Hurricane Helene surge, Sep 26 2024; Idalia, Aug 2023

11. Cedar Key
Hurricane Idalia record surge, Aug 30 2023; Helene, Sep 2024; Hermine, 2016

12. St. Pete Beach
Hurricane Helene surge, Sep 26 2024; Idalia, Aug 2023

13. Navarre Beach
Hurricane Ivan, Sep 2004; Dennis landfall on Santa Rosa Island, Jul 2005

14. Siesta Key
Hurricane Helene surge, Sep 2024; Milton landfall nearby, Oct 9 2024

15. Longboat Key
Hurricane Helene surge, Sep 2024; Milton, Oct 2024

16. St. Augustine
Hurricane Matthew, Oct 2016; Irma, Sep 2017 (back-to-back downtown flooding)

17. Pensacola Beach
Hurricane Ivan, Sep 2004; Opal, Oct 1995; Dennis, Jul 2005; Sally, Sep 2020

18. Flagler Beach
Hurricane Irma, 2017; Nicole, Nov 2022 (A1A and dune damage); Matthew, 2016

19. Palm Beach
Hurricanes Frances and Jeanne, Sep 2004

20. Naples
Hurricane Ian surge, Sep 2022 (record at the Naples tide gauge); Irma, 2017

21. Cocoa Beach
Hurricane Irma, 2017; Frances and Jeanne, 2004

22. Jacksonville Beach
Hurricane Matthew, Oct 2016; Irma, Sep 2017

23. Apalachicola
Hurricane Michael, Oct 2018; Idalia surge, Aug 2023

24. Hallandale Beach
June 2024 South Florida flooding; Apr 2023 rain flood

25. New Smyrna Beach
Hurricane Ian rain flood, Sep 2022; Nicole, Nov 2022

THE FLOODS PEOPLE REMEMBER, CONTINUED

26. Hollywood
Apr 2023 South Florida rain flood; June 2024 South Florida flooding

27. Fort Lauderdale
Apr 12–13 2023 record rain (~26 in in about a day at FLL airport)

28. Cape Coral
Hurricane Ian surge and wind, Sep 2022

29. Santa Rosa Beach (30A)
Hurricane Opal, Oct 1995; Dennis, Jul 2005

30. Ormond Beach
Hurricane Matthew, Oct 2016; Ian rain flood, Sep 2022; Nicole, Nov 2022

31. Mexico Beach
Hurricane Michael Cat 5 landfall, Oct 10 2018 (town largely destroyed)

32. Fernandina Beach
Hurricane Matthew, Oct 2016; Irma, Sep 2017

33. Sarasota
Hurricane Helene surge, Sep 2024; Milton, Oct 2024

34. Vero Beach
Hurricanes Frances and Jeanne, Sep 2004; Nicole, Nov 2022

35. Pompano Beach
Hurricane Irma, 2017; Wilma, 2005

36. Daytona Beach
Hurricane Ian rain flood, Sep 2022; Nicole surge, Nov 2022; Milton, Oct 2024

37. Panama City Beach
Hurricane Opal, Oct 1995; Michael, Oct 2018

38. Clearwater
Hurricane Helene surge on Clearwater Beach, Sep 2024; 1993 Storm of the Century

39. Venice
Hurricanes Helene and Milton, 2024

40. West Palm Beach
Hurricane Frances, Sep 2004; Irene, 1999

41. Satellite Beach
Hurricane Matthew, Oct 2016; Nicole beach and dune erosion, Nov 2022

42. Fort Pierce
Hurricanes Frances and Jeanne, Sep 2004; Nicole, Nov 2022

43. Boca Raton
Hurricane Irma, 2017

44. Destin
Hurricane Opal, Oct 1995; Ivan, Sep 2004

45. Delray Beach
Hurricane Irene, 1999; Irma, 2017

46. Palm Bay
Nov 2 2026 extreme rain (up to 22.8 in near Grant-Valkaria; Turkey Creek crest 19.96 ft); Tropical Storm Fay, Aug 2008

47. Jupiter
Hurricane Frances, 2004

48. Melbourne
Nov 2 2026 extreme rain (about 11 in, a daily record); Tropical Storm Fay, Aug 2008

49. Fort Walton Beach
Hurricane Opal, Oct 1995; Ivan, Sep 2004

50. Stuart
Hurricanes Frances and Jeanne, Sep 2004

WHERE THE MAPS DISAGREE

The two maps measure different things, so a few towns rank very differently on each. Percentile compares each town with the other 49 (100 = most land affected).

FEMA shows more risk than the tide map

Little land sits within 3 ft of high tide, but FEMA maps sizable rain, river, lake or surge zones.

TOWN	TIDE (+3 FT) · PERCENTILE	FEMA · PERCENTILE
Panama City Beach rank 37	0.3% · 4	50.1% · 48
West Palm Beach rank 40	0.3% · 2	47.4% · 45
Daytona Beach rank 36	0.5% · 8	50.1% · 48
Mexico Beach rank 31	1.0% · 18	55.4% · 57
Palm Bay rank 46	0.2% · 0	29.3% · 29

The tide map shows more risk than FEMA

These towns rank much higher on low, ocean connected land than on FEMA's high risk map.

TOWN	TIDE (+3 FT) · PERCENTILE	FEMA · PERCENTILE
Cocoa Beach rank 21	31.7% · 80	44.4% · 37
Jacksonville Beach rank 22	24.7% · 74	38.9% · 33
Apalachicola rank 23	23.3% · 71	44.0% · 35
Flagler Beach rank 18	29.9% · 78	45.4% · 43

SOURCES AND NOTES

Tide flooding: NOAA Office for Coastal Management, Sea Level Rise Viewer (+1, +2 and +3 ft above recent normal high tide, MHHW; ocean connected areas only).

Town boundaries: US Census boundaries (TIGERweb 2026 places). Santa Rosa Beach (30A) = ZIP 32459; Pensacola Beach = ZIP 32561 on Santa Rosa Island.

FEMA high risk zone: FEMA National Flood Hazard Layer (Special Flood Hazard Area: A, AE, VE and similar).

Scores rank these 50 towns against each other; they are not a guarantee for any single property. Neither map counts heavy rain flooding. Prepared November 2026 by Florida Coastal from NOAA, FEMA and US Census public data.